

Academia denounces “attack” on “academic freedom”

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The university community is taking a stand against the treatment of the University of Ottawa teacher denounced for having mentioned the word “nigger” in a course. Professor Verushka Lieutenant-Duval was suspended, then reinstated in her duties for using this word in class, even without malicious intent. [A letter signed by 579 CEGEP and university professors](#), transmitted to *Duty*, denounces this “serious precedent which attacks academic freedom head-on”.

“The University of Ottawa is on the wrong target. We do not tackle the problem of racism by punishing and prohibiting the teaching of words, works and authors who, on the contrary, reveal it and explicitly combat it”, indicates the letter written by Mathieu Gauthier, professor of philosophy. at Cégep Garneau, and Murielle Chapuis, professor of literature at Cégep Lionel-Groulx.

“It is urgent that higher education institutions adopt a clear policy in order to protect the integrity of knowledge and its passers-by. This must include, among other things, the recognition of the right to reasonable disagreement and that of the principle of charity. The social context and patronage cannot prevail over knowledge and its dissemination,” add the authors.

The reactions to this controversy were so strong that by mid-afternoon Monday, 579 teachers had already signed the letter. Mathieu Gauthier deplores the way in which the University of Ottawa has handled this affair.

“Systemic racism”

The rector of the establishment, Jacques Frémont, broke his silence of the last few days, Monday, by explaining the thread of events. “Members of dominant groups simply do not have the legitimacy to decide what constitutes micro-aggression,” Frémont wrote in a post on the University of Ottawa website.

“Our university has experienced racist or racist incidents for over a year and a half. We have held several town halls where difficult conversations took place on the various

manifestations of racism at the University. We are, like many other universities, in the process of becoming aware of the various manifestations of this systemic racism, well anchored in our ways of doing things and we have made a commitment to work to remedy the situation”, he added. he adds.

The rector recalled that the teacher offered to discuss the question of the use of the “word beginning with – n” in a subsequent lesson. “It is part of his academic freedom and he will be free to do so. But it should come as no surprise that many of his students simply do not want, especially in the momentum of the Black Lives Matter (BLM) movement, to once again have to justify themselves so that their right to dignity. be respected. During the incident, the teacher had the choice, in her words, to use or not the word starting with – n; it has chosen to do so with the consequences that we know, ”adds Jacques Frémont.

Difficulty in teaching

The rector assures us that Professor Lieutenant-Duval has remained an employee of the University of Ottawa. “During the few days that she did not teach, the University organized an orderly return to class with its full cooperation. She is free to continue her course, which she did last Friday, as usual, enjoying her full academic freedom. “

The 579 signatories of the letter deplore the obstacles placed on the shoulders of teachers who are trying to diversify the content of their courses. ” [...] how can we teach the very relevant film without this word *I am not your negro* by Raoul Peck, or the artistic current of negritude of Léopold Sédar Senghor and Aimé Césaire? How to refer to the classic work of Pierre Vallières, explain the multiple meanings of “Speak white” in Michèle Lalonde’s poem, evoke the universe of Toni Morrison or the work of Dany Laferrière – *How to have sex with a nigger without getting tired* -, an eminently satirical book? “

The signatories point out that “this is the third time that the use and mention of words have been confused”, after the cases of Wendy Mesley of the CBC and Professor Catherine Russell of Concordia University.